

your first year, a little easier

The First-Year Starter Pack

A short guide, a planner, and the check-ins I wish my family had in our first year of online school and homeschooling.

PRINTABLE PDF · 13 PAGES

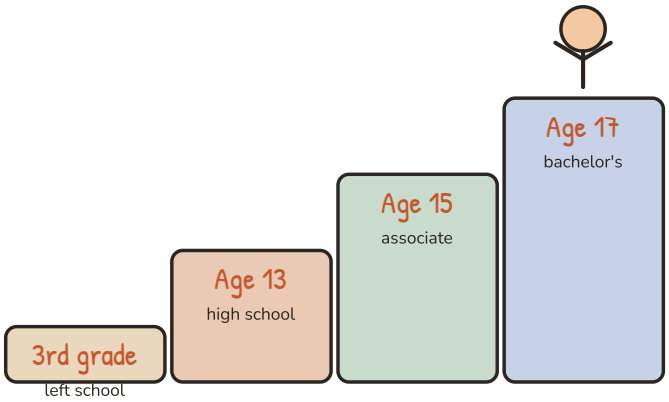
by Fabian Capre

welcome

Hi, I'm Fabian

And this is the pack I wish we'd had.

When I was pulled out of in-person school in the middle of third grade, nobody handed my family a map. My first year of online school was rough. This pack is a shortcut through the parts we learned the hard way.



I finished high school at 13 through FLVS Flex, earned my associate degree at 15 and my bachelor's at 17. But this pack isn't about speed. It's about fit: building the first year around the child.

What's inside

1. My first year, honestly
2. What worked and what didn't
3. Plan your days
4. Find community on purpose
5. The feedback talk
6. Five first-year principles
7. The planner pages (year, week, month, reset)
8. A quick readiness check

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part 1

My first year, honestly

What it was really like, in my own words.

I was pulled out in the middle of the school year, which meant I didn't get to say goodbye to most of my friends. At school, the classroom told me where to be and what to do all day. Online, I had lecture times and assignments, and once they were done I was free for the rest of the day. I wasn't used to that freedom.

I also missed the social side so much that, for a while, I honestly thought homeschool social life didn't exist. It did. My parents just didn't know yet what they could sign me up for. It took about a year of settling in before they found the activities and local groups that filled the gap.

> *I told my parents that I missed being in school and felt like I was missing a piece of my childhood. They didn't get defensive.*

They understood it was a process they were still learning about too. I'm one of three brothers, and my other two later followed the same path, so in a way I was going in blindly with my parents and paving the way.

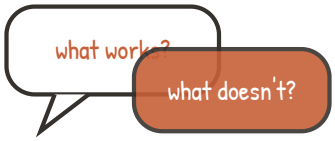
If your family is in year one

The hard first stretch is normal. It's not a sign you chose wrong. It's a sign you're adjusting, and adjusting is something you can plan for.

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part 2

What worked, and what didn't



What worked

- **My own pace,** with an online instructor I could turn to
- **Telling my parents** what was and wasn't working, and them listening
- **Finding community on purpose**, even though it took a year
- **Time for ideas I was curious about**
- **Getting used to the freedom**, and learning to plan it

What didn't

- **Expecting it to feel like school** at home
- **Missing friends** and not knowing what to sign up for
- **Too much open time** with no plan for it
- **Waiting for the hard feelings to pass** without saying anything

What I wish my parents (and I) had known

1. The first year will be the hardest. Plan for it.
2. Say how you feel early, even when it's awkward.
3. Look for activities before you feel lonely, not after.
4. Free time isn't a gap. It's a gift if you plan it.

What's working for us so far

What isn't

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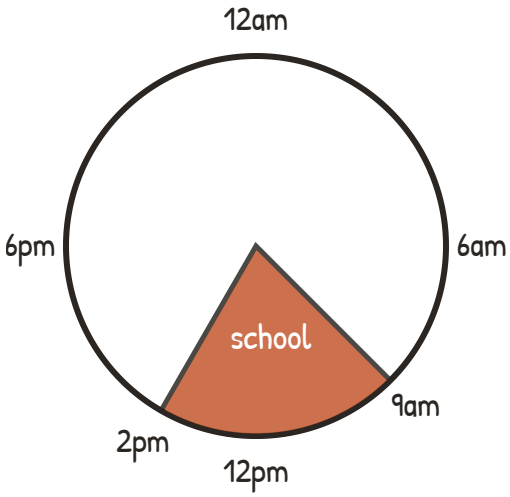
part 3

Plan your days

A simple shape for a day that leaves room to breathe.

My day started at 9 and finished around 2. That left the rest of the afternoon for other school activities and things I was interested in, like a trip to the park.

The schedule itself worked. What I'd change is my **outlook**: I wasn't used to that much free time, and it took a while to treat it as something to plan around instead of a gap to fill.



My daily shape (yours can look different)

	What I did	Your version
9 to ~2	Lectures, assignments, review	
After 2	Free time: activities, interests, friends	
Evening	Rest	

Plan the free time

- [ ] Pick three things your learner would love to do each week
- [ ] Put one on the calendar before the week starts
- [ ] Leave one slot completely open
- [ ] Ask them: what do you want to do with this time?

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part 4

Find community on purpose



It didn't happen automatically for me, and it may not for you.

Places to look

- Local clubs and organizations (check each group's rules)
- Faith and community groups
- Classes and co-ops
- Volunteering
- Sports and arts
- Friends of different ages

Questions to ask

- How many regular activities does the week have?
- Does my child have at least one friend to talk to freely?
- Do they invite others and get invited?

Activity or group	Contact	Day / time	Tried it?	Notes

From my experience

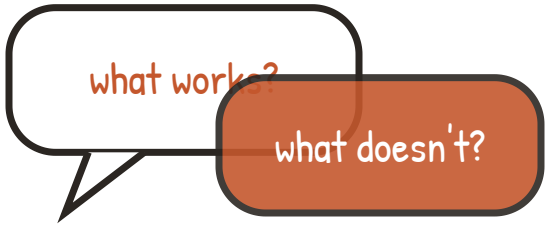
Once my parents found local activities, I joined local high school clubs and organizations and church groups, and later college clubs. I had as much social life as anyone, maybe more. But it started with a year of looking.

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part 5

The feedback talk

The habit that changed the most for me.



For parents, try

- "What's one thing that's working for you?"
- "What's one thing that isn't?"
- "If you could change one thing, what would it be?"
- "What would make this week better?"

Listen first. Write it down. Don't defend.

For students, try

- "What works for me is ____."
- "What doesn't is ____."
- "Can we try changing one thing?"
- "I miss ____, and I'd like help finding it."

It's information, not complaining.

This week we agreed to change

We'll check in again on

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part 6

Five first-year principles



1. **Build around the child.**

   Face to face, online with an instructor, or no lectures at all. There's no single right style, only what fits.

2. **Don't recreate school at home.**

   The same linear, one-sided lessons at the kitchen table aren't the goal. Adapt the experience.

3. **Ask, listen, change one thing.**

   Check in monthly. Change one thing at a time.

4. **Plan the social side and the free time.**

   Both took me a year to figure out. You can start sooner.

5. **Fit before speed.**

   Finishing early was one outcome for me, and not the only good one. Go as fast as fits, and no faster.

> A reminder
>
> Every child is different. This is one person's experience, and your family will find its own way.

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start here

Year at a Glance

Where you are, where you might go, and the one thing you'll try.

Learner (nickname is fine, no personal details needed)

	Where we are now	What's working	What isn't	One thing we'll try
Learning style (live instructor, online instructor, reading, hands-on)				
Pace				
Daily structure				
Social life				
Goals (not just graduation)				

The route we're considering

What would tell us it's time to slow down?

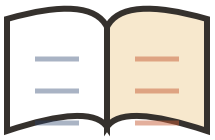
From my experience

I wasn't a passenger in my own education. Telling my parents what worked and what didn't, and watching them change things, mattered more than any curriculum.

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each week

Weekly Planner



Week of _____ Energy this week (1-5): ____

Day	Learning block 1	Learning block 2	Break / movement	Friends or activity
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Weekend				

The protected fun slot

Friday review: what worked

What to change

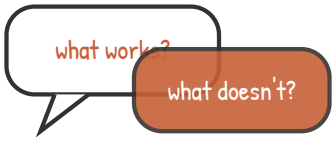
What worked for me

My day ran from about 9 to 2, and the rest was free for other activities and things I was curious about. The free time only felt like a gift once I started planning it.

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each month

Monthly Check-In



Sit down together, relaxed. Month of _____

The learner fills in

Something I enjoyed

Something that was hard

Something I want to change

Energy (1-5): 1 2 3 4 5

I want to go: faster / slower / the same

The parent fills in

I noticed they seemed

Something I'm worried about

Something I'll change on my side

Decision for next month, together

A note

Honest, not for judging. If you see ongoing dread, loss of interest, or changes in sleep or mood, slow down, and talk to a qualified professional if you're worried.

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when things feel stuck

Reset Plan



A rough stretch is a signal to adjust, not a failure.

What's been hardest

The one thing we'll change

What we're pausing

Who we'll talk to

What we're keeping

Review date

The steps

1. Stop adding new commitments for two weeks.
2. Have one honest conversation.
3. Protect sleep, play and friends.
4. Pick one thing to change.
5. Recheck in two weeks.
6. Decide together: continue, adjust or pause.

What didn't work for me

My first year of online school was hard: no classroom structure, lots of free time I wasn't used to, and missing friends. It got better, but only after we changed things on purpose.

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quick check

A fast readiness check

Five questions. Circle one answer each.

1 Does the learner say what works and what doesn't about how they learn?

◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

2 Is at least one adult checking in regularly?

◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

3 Are you open to changing the plan when something isn't working?

◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

4 Is there a plan for friends and activities?

◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

5 Are you clear that finishing early is one outcome, not the goal?

◯ Yes ◯ Not sure ◯ No

What's next

Pick one thing from this pack to try this week. Do the monthly check-in on the same day each month. If the first year feels hard, you're not behind. You're adjusting.

About the author

Fabian Capre left in-person school in 3rd grade and was homeschooled from then on. He completed high school through FLVS Flex in 2021 at 13, earned his associate degree in political science from Palm Beach State College in 2023 at 15, and his bachelor's degree in political science from Florida Atlantic University in 2025 at 17. He is now working on a master's degree.

He is not a licensed teacher, counselor or lawyer. He shares what worked for him, what was hard, and what he would do differently.

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